

THE NATURE OF PSYCHOLOGICAL KINDS

Historical roots of psychological categories

Traditional prescriptions for the practice of a scientific psychology seem to imply an image of the psychologist as a sort of visitor from outer space (Ingleby, 1990), unaffected by local cultural traditions or the preconceptions embedded in human language. Right at the beginning of this book that image was rejected in favour of one that depicts psychology as a cultural construction with specific historical roots. The body of the book was devoted to an exploration of some of these roots. In light of this exploration, what can we say about the sources of psychological categories? Obviously, these categories all depend on certain semantic traditions and a historically emerging usage. Is it possible to go beyond such general statements by identifying some of the major factors in the historical formation of psychological categories?

I propose to answer this question positively by first recalling the various layers of discourse that have been examined in the preceding pages. At each of these levels a particular set of conceptual distinctions emerges so as to form a specific network of interconnected categories that enables a certain kind of understanding of human subjects.

At a relatively deep level there are broad distinctions that have pervasive effects. In this book we have concentrated on the distinctions introduced by a certain kind of moral discourse that first became fully articulate in eighteenth-century Britain. Aiding both self-understanding and self-justification under new social and economic circumstances, this discourse was based on a fundamental sense of separation between human individuals as well as between individual agents and their actions. In Chapter 3 we saw how this manifested itself in the emergence of a network of categories with modern meanings, such as self, consciousness and motive. The new moral sensibility also involved revolutionary changes in the understanding of ancient categories like reason and passion without which modern conceptions of intelligence and emotion would have remained literally unthinkable.

Had there been no further developments psychology would have remained simply a part of moral discourse. In part, it has indeed

remained so, but of course the special authority of modern Psychology derives, not from its moral implications, but from its scientific pretensions. These latter depend on its methodology and on its use of categories that carry a special scientific aura. Twentieth-century Psychology talks not only of motives and emotions but also of stimuli and organisms. Such categories have their origin in biology, not in moral philosophy. They constitute a different layer of historical development. Their psychological use is predicated upon the emergence of a distinction between a physiological and a psychological domain and upon the troubled history of that distinction. This was explored in Chapter 4. But beyond that, the biological heritage weighs heavily on pervasive categories of twentieth-century Psychology, like behaviour and learning, as well as more specific categories like intelligence (Chapters 5 and 6). In all these cases, an essentially biological understanding of human action and human capability was built into the categories used for their depiction.

A third layer of psychological discourse was added with the professionalization of psychology and its institutionalization as a discipline. These developments entailed the creation of a class of psychological specialists whose very existence imposed new functions on psychological language. Previously, psychological distinctions and psychological terms had been everyone's property, and psychological usage had become widely diffused in philosophical, medical, educational and literary texts. This diffusion did not end in the twentieth century – quite the contrary. But there now emerged an ever growing army of experts whose pronouncements on matters psychological were of a special kind, because they were supposedly founded on the indisputable authority of science. These experts claimed to have a superior kind of access to psychological knowledge that was not available to those outside the fold of science. In due course, the activities of members of this new class led to the formation of a new layer of psychological language, partly for internal use among themselves and partly for use in their dealings with the lay public or with other groups of specialists. In part, this new layer was composed of a myriad of technical terms, each relevant to a relatively limited domain. In this book, however, the focus has not been on that aspect of the new psychological language but on the more subtle adaptation of existing terms to describe major domains reshaped by the activity of the new professionals.

The establishment of a recognized class of psychological specialists always depended on their maintaining a delicate balance between the ideal of a universalistic and uninvolved science and accommodation to the requirements of local sectoral interests. Without the former, no special authority claims could be upheld in the long run; without the latter, there was no employment and scant social support, material and otherwise. This balancing act was reflected in many of the general categories around which the new specialists organized their work.

Among the examples discussed in this book the categories of intelligence, learning and motivation show this most clearly. In each of these there was a melding of a putatively biological category with categories derived from specific social practices, i.e. social selection in the case of intelligence, educational practices in the case of learning, and management practices in the case of motivation. That made it possible to provide a whole array of local social practices with an apparently scientific justification, a function at which the new professionals excelled.

If the new Psychology was to be a science relevant to life outside the laboratory its categories had to suit the practical contexts in which it was beginning to be applied. As a result, psychological language became enriched by an array of terms that had already achieved some currency in those contexts. A few of these terms – such as the ones examined in this book – came to define categories of psychological phenomena to which a fundamental significance was attached. They served as a focus for psychological research and differentiated the domains of psychological knowledge. Why did they, and not others, achieve this status? As I have already suggested, that depended on the ease with which they could be assimilated to quasi-biological categories of apparently universal validity.

The combination of a universal biological meaning with a local social meaning was mediated by the development of specific technologies. Certain investigative practices, certain methods of psychological research and assessment – intelligence and personality testing, techniques for measuring the strength of attitudes and motives, standard learning situations, and so on, provided the basis for constituting classes of scientifically validated phenomena that could be produced in a variety of practical settings. In the course of time, the role of such technologies in establishing the meaning of psychological categories became ever more decisive.

With the growth of a professional community of psychologists the meaning of psychological categories also began to be affected by the role they played in the life of this community of experts. The categories in question were involved, not only in the interaction of experts with their lay public, but also in the internal communication on which the cohesion of the scientific community depended. This factor emerges particularly strongly in the development of a kind of metalanguage – as described in Chapter 9 – which functions as a *lingua franca* among members of the discipline. Here too, the role of certain technologies is critical. Another aspect of the life of the disciplinary community that may have effects on the meaning of categories is its relationship to neighbouring communities of experts. Professional rivalries and attempts at maintaining or extending disciplinary boundaries play a role here. One example of such effects was noted in Chapter 8 in connection with the history of the category 'social attitude' which was more or less annexed by Psychology, only to be given an essentially asocial meaning.

The intervention of a third layer of effects through the emergence of disciplinary communities by no means abolishes the other two layers. Scientific psychological categories still have to be consonant with culturally sanctioned assumptions about humans and their relationship to the world, and they also continue to be shaped by established scientific traditions. Disciplinary communities have only a limited space within which to reshape categories in accordance with their own requirements. Their members remain bound by philosophies that have come to be taken for granted in their culture as well as by traditional interpretations of the meaning of their own practices (MacIntyre, 1984: 221).

The politics of psychological language

Whether it was a matter of providing a framework for a moral philosophy appropriate to social relations based on contract and exchange, whether it was a matter of rationalizing particular scientific procedures and ideologies, or whether the interests of professionalizing groups of experts were at stake, the categories constituted in psychological language were intimately linked to particular social practices. Although it was always claimed to be simply a reflection of some objectively existing psychological reality, the meaning of these categories always depended on the use to which they were put in specific social contexts. Psychological classificatory terms established a framework for communicating about certain aspects of human life and experience, and such communication was never entirely disinterested, uninvolved or innocent. Historical actors operated within and upon this framework in order to accomplish certain ends, to produce certain effects and prevent others. When the constraints of received categories no longer suited current actors, they began using them in ways that altered their meaning. They also invented new categories, often by emphasizing distinctions that had not seemed important before, or by grouping together things that had previously seemed to be quite different.

It hardly needs pointing out that the phenomena involved here are strictly *public* phenomena. The texts that make use of and convey the meaning of psychological categories exist in a domain of public discourse where they may have effects on the way readers pursue their own work, and on their understanding of their own actions, even their feelings and hopes. The authors of such texts are well aware of this and aim to *do* something with their words (Skinner, 1988b), though what they accomplish may not be what they had hoped for. In other words, the texts constitute a public domain to which individuals may sometimes contribute as innovators but which also constrains and affects their thoughts and actions. Whatever personal significance authors' contributions may have had for them may be of biographical interest but is not

germane to an analysis of the historical development of public discourse. Once in the public domain these contributions mingle with the effects of countless other contributions and become part of a discursive formation that must be analysed on its own terms.

It would be a mistake to pursue this analysis in terms of distinctions derived from traditional accounts of the activity of isolated knowers. Such accounts usually distinguish between *concepts* assumed to exist inside an individual mind and the *language* that an individual uses to label and describe these concepts. This distinction does not apply at the level of public discourse. Here there is only a language and the manner of its deployment by certain users. The life of concepts is studied as part of this context, not as the content of private minds. Hence the distinction between a concept that is essentially private and a language that is essentially public becomes inapplicable. In this book, as the reader may have noticed, such a distinction is not made. Nor are concepts attributed with a power and an essence of their own, as used to be the fashion in the quaint idealist historiography of old. Language only acts as the carrier of concepts insofar as it is deployed by its users in specific discursive contexts.

At this level, psychological language must be studied as part of social life and that means taking account of its political role. Common ways of describing the character of human actions, the constitution of human individuals, the contours of human experience, always have social consequences and are unlikely to be politically innocent (Deetz, 1994). The categories of such descriptions often provide a resource for justifying particular social arrangements and legitimizing social practices by establishing a taken for granted discursive framework. Political changes are usually implicated in conceptual transformation, and vice versa (Farr, 1989).

Psychological categories have a political dimension because they are not purely descriptive but also normative. Adopting a particular classification of psychological phenomena, and implicitly rejecting a myriad possible alternative classifications, means establishing a certain form for the recognition of human conduct and human individuality. Whatever people are, whatever they do, will be recognized only in the forms prescribed by some system of classification. For instance, in the prevailing Western system everyone is expected to have private motives, everyone is expected to have social attitudes, everyone is expected to fall somewhere in the distribution of intelligence. In principle, individuals could claim that these categories misrepresented their own experience, but the social and scientific pressures are such that virtually no one does. For most persons the prevailing discursive system becomes inescapable and motives, attitudes, intelligence and so on are the forms in which they experience their own subjectivity.¹ The discursive resources that might enable people to experience themselves and others differently are generally not available.

It is not only in this sense that prevailing psychological categories are normative. These categories invariably function as conduits for the transmission of social evaluation. Thus, intelligence, even test intelligence, constitutes a criterion for judging people; the concept of attitude establishes a focus for the expression of encouragement or discouragement; and the reification of motives provides a whole vocabulary for expressing approval or disapproval of particular courses of action.

While psychological categories had long functioned in this way in the informal situations of everyday life, psychological science gradually achieved a privileged position with regard to their use in more formal settings. When educationists decided on a child's life chances, when the military designed programmes to boost morale, when advertisers looked for ways of influencing consumers, they were likely to make use of the categories of intelligence, attitude and motivation, respectively. But they used them in a rationalized context where some means of demonstrating and comparing the effectiveness of their actions was required (cf. Porter, 1995). Psychological science could supply these means through the standardized techniques of measurement which it had developed. In this way the categories of psychological investigation, defined by these techniques, were transformed into categories of institutional practice. Concomitantly, disciplinary power was extended from phenomena produced under laboratory-like conditions to phenomena that formed part of life outside the laboratory. Such political consequences were not necessarily intended by anyone, but, given the appropriate cultural context, they tended to follow from the anchoring of category meaning in a technology designed for that purpose by specialists with a particular professional identity.

The reference of psychological categories

It may well be that the categories of scientific psychology have political effects but nevertheless represent natural divisions among objective features of the world that exist independently of the efforts of psychologists. This is certainly how most psychologists think of the categories they employ in their work. They tend to use them as though they referred to 'natural kinds', groups of naturally occurring phenomena that inherently resemble each other and differ crucially from other phenomena. Is there any validity to this view?

To answer this question it is necessary, first, to remind oneself that the categories one meets in psychological texts are discursive categories, forms of words, not the things themselves. There is a distinction, often ignored by practitioners, between the language used to describe a particular set of phenomena and the phenomena themselves (Gergen, 1982, 1985). We can read the descriptive text, but what exactly is the relationship between it and whatever it is that it refers to? Psychological

categories are discursive objects that supposedly refer to something outside discourse (Danziger, 1993). But how do they refer? Are they a mirror held up to the world that reflects the divisions to be found there?

This image may be appropriate for the relationship an isolated individual might have with a natural world lacking all human qualities. In this model the individual forms some kind of mental representation of objects that are out there and learns to apply verbal labels to them. The objects carry on with their existence irrespective of this process. They don't care what they are called or if they are called anything at all, and their natural existence in no way depends on how they are represented by any human individual. But as soon as we substitute artificial for natural objects – that is, objects created by humans – the situation changes. Now, the existence of the object, perhaps an axe or a god, does depend in some way on how it is represented by its creator – had it been represented in some other way it would have been created differently. In other words, the relationship between verbal labels or mental images and their objective reference has ceased to be *merely* representational and has become at least partly *constitutional*. The way the object is constituted now depends on its human creator and the relationship between the object's existence and its representation has become quite intimate. A plan for a building, for example, is not simply a representation of something that would exist without such a plan, it is something that imposes a particular form on what it depicts.

The conduct of scientific investigations has much in common with the design of buildings. This is partly recognized when we use the same word, design, in reference to the planning of buildings and the planning of experiments. But it goes further than that. The experimental outcome would not exist had the experimenters not intervened in the natural course of events. Experimental outcomes are artefacts, not natural phenomena. At the very least, they are co-constituted by human agents. Of course this also applies to the phenomena produced through the administration of psychological tests, questionnaires, rating scales, or any other instrument of investigation.

Among the instruments of investigation the most basic one is often overlooked. It is language. Without language the other instruments could not be constructed, the results of investigations could not be described, hypotheses could not be formulated, and investigators could not arrive at a common understanding of what they were doing. No wonder that the role of language is so often overlooked in texts dealing with the technique of investigation. It is a case of the fish being the last animal to discover water. The entire investigative enterprise is so immersed in language that it is simply taken for granted and its role becomes invisible. Language, however, is not a neutral medium; it is crucial for the constitution of the phenomena under investigation. Nothing ever

becomes an object of investigation without being categorized in some way, even if the classification changes in the course of the investigation. This categorization gives the object its identity and enables investigators to have a particular understanding of what they are doing.

Investigators, like everyone else, live in a world that has already been classified. The best scientific work may lead to a questioning of an existing category, but much of the time research proceeds within a framework of established categories. Even when the meaning of a category is questioned, it is unlikely to be one of the fundamental categories that define the field. It is only in exceptional circumstances, as when a new discipline is created or redefined, that the work of category construction is displayed openly on a large scale. This book has examined such a case. The period that has provided its major focus, the early part of this century, was a period during which the discipline of Psychology was remaking itself, particularly in the US, and the construction of new categories as well as the reworking of old ones was very much part of this process.

Quite clearly, the display of new phenomena was part of this. I say 'display', and not 'discovery', because the nature of the process by which new phenomena entered the discourse of the discipline is precisely what is at issue here. To say that these phenomena were 'discovered' is to prejudge the issue in favour of the much criticized mirror model of classification. According to the classical version of this model, individuals first find new features in the world and then alter their concepts and categories to get a better reflection of a world that now includes the new features. However, the process may be the reverse of this. New features may emerge as a result of a different way of classifying and conceptualizing; it may then be more appropriate to speak of a process of construction rather than discovery.² But perhaps that implies a degree of freedom that the investigator does not have. So let us simply say that the new features are displayed.

Displayed to whom? Not simply to a solitary investigator, surely, for we are not dealing with a secret art like alchemy but with science, which is a form of public knowledge. For public display some conventions of representation are necessary, and these always rely on a language, artificial or natural. Even a graph or a table of figures must be verbally labelled, that is interpreted, to convey its proper meaning. A scientific fact is always a fact under some description. The discursive framework within which factual description takes place is as much part of science as its hardware and its techniques of measurement. To be effective, such a framework must be shared – an idiosyncratic description of a fact will not be accepted as a scientific statement. In other words, the work of reference is not a solitary labour but a social activity. Any reference to the 'facts of the world' has to rely on some discursive framework in use among a particular group of people at a particular time. Facts are there to be displayed, but they can only be displayed within a certain

discursive structure.³ Changes in these structures present opportunities for the display of different facts.

As we have seen, the categories of psychological discourse have changed quite considerably in the course of time. This was a change that was closely connected with broad social changes as well as with the concerns, material, ideological and professional, of emerging groups of specialists. Psychological categories were always relevant to the lives of those who used them, whether they were ordinary people or experts. Changes in these lives were accompanied by changes in psychological categories. Although it is difficult to say that these categories represent *natural* kinds, what one can say is that they represent *relevant* kinds.⁴ They are relevant to the people who use them, relevant to their concerns, their interrelationships with each other, their possibilities of action. There are factors in their lives which lead them to make and to emphasize certain distinctions and to ignore any number of others. That is reflected in the changes in psychological categories that we have traced in this book.

Natural kinds or human kinds?

Should one regard psychological categories as natural kinds? Initially, I mentioned two criteria for the existence of a natural kind: that it be independent of the efforts of investigators, in this case psychologists, and that there be some inherent resemblance among the phenomena belonging to a kind. In light of the foregoing discussion and the historical material considered in the preceding chapters there seem to be no grounds for accepting the 'naturalness' of psychological categories on the basis of the first criterion. The second criterion requires a little further consideration.

Even if one grants that systems of classification depend on the people doing the classifying, one could still maintain that a particular system provides the most accurate, the most veridical, representation of the natural resemblances that exist in the objective world. The underlying idea would be that natural divisions are of a kind that permits only one true representation, all other versions being departures from this one truth. What is wrong with this idea is its attribution to some world outside our experience of features that are specifically features of shared experienced worlds. In particular, the existence of defined objects distinguished from each other by certain patterns of resemblance is as much a feature of shared experienced worlds as is the existence of schemes of classification (Putnam, 1981). The two go hand in hand. Strictly speaking, there are no 'raw' data in science. Whatever forms the subject of scientifically informed perception is already classified in some way. This does not mean that such perceptions depend on nothing but discourse; what it means is that scientific discourse is only able to

represent objects as they have been constituted by the categories of that discourse.⁵

Furthermore, the very notion of natural kinds may be peculiarly inappropriate for psychology. A defining characteristic of natural objects that I have already referred to is their indifference to the descriptions applied to them. If we change our identification of a chemical compound as a result of advances in techniques of analysis, this changes our knowledge of the compound but the compound itself remains the same compound it always was. But the objects represented in psychological language are generally not like that. A person who learns not to think of his or her actions as greedy or avaricious but as motivated by a need for achievement or self-realization has changed as a person. Students who learn to classify things they see under a microscope no longer have the same perceptual experience they had during their initial encounter with microscopic preparations. The sorts of things that psychology takes as its objects, people's actions, experiences and dispositions, are not independent of their categorization.

There are two reasons for this. First, the individuals who are the carriers of psychological objects are able to represent these objects to themselves in a self-referential fashion. Unless one joins the behaviourists in assigning a purely epiphenomenal status to such representations, it is apparent that their existence introduces a profound distinction between psychological objects and natural objects that have no capacity for self-reference. The manner of their articulation in language becomes a constituent part of psychological objects so that their identity changes with changes in psychological language (Taylor, 1985).

Secondly, psychological properties are intelligible features of the world only by virtue of their display within a discursive context. They do not exist preformed in some private realm before they enter into social life. Whatever forms they assume are due to their embeddedness in particular discursive practices. The conception of psychological entities as natural objects is often grounded in a naive belief in the existence of a private world of psychological essences. However, distinctions that constitute emotions as emotions, motives as motives, cognitions as cognitions, and so on, do not exist in some sealed private box *before* they are so labelled in public.⁶ Identifying experiences, actions and dispositions is not like sticking labels on fully formed specimens in a museum. Psychological objects assume their identity in the course of discursive interaction among individuals.

Distinguishing among kinds of actions and kinds of people is part of human interaction everywhere. Psychology attempts to offer causal explanations of the domains created by these distinctions, using empirical investigation and theoretical hypotheses. The extent to which these attempts act back on the distinctions themselves depends on the authority commanded by psychological expertise in a particular culture. It also depends on the way in which psychological work relates to

existing needs and interests. If the work is truly innovative and threatens established preconceptions and relationships it will meet a great deal of resistance. But the great bulk of psychological work has never been in any danger of this fate. Both in its inspiration and in its effects it has been profoundly conservative. Except on a very superficial level, it has shared the prevailing preconceptions of its culture and arranged its investigations in such a way that no knowledge with revolutionary implications could possibly emerge from them. In assessing the effect of psychological science on psychological kinds it is easy to overlook the biggest effect of all, namely, the reinforcement of existing culturally embedded preconceptions and distinctions.⁷

This cultural embeddedness accounts for the taken for granted quality that so many psychological categories possess. It is a quality that makes them appear 'natural' to the members of a particular speech community sharing a certain tradition of language usage. However, this sense of 'natural' is not to be confused with the concept of natural kinds that has featured in the present discussion. Natural kinds have nothing to do with culture, whereas the natural-appearing kinds of psychology have everything to do with it. We need a term for the latter that will recognize this distinction. The term 'human kind', introduced by Ian Hacking (1992), is useful here. Hacking's main interest is in categories that define kinds of people, like homosexual or multiple personality disorder, but, in principle, kinds of human activity are covered too. The difference between natural and human kinds rests on the distinctions I have already mentioned, that is, whether the kind is self-referring and whether it is intrinsically part of social practice. The categories discussed in this book are all human kinds rather than natural kinds.

One consequence of the distinguishing features of human kinds is that their relationship to the reality they refer to is different from that of natural kinds. The latter refer to something that would be the case, whether any particular act of reference had occurred or not. Human kinds, on the other hand, affect that which they refer to. Historically, 'the category and the people in it emerged hand in hand' (Hacking, 1986: 229). The way humans categorize themselves and their activities is not independent of their actual conduct, because, as we have noted, such categorization is part of human conduct and therefore not a matter of indifference to the people concerned. This leads to what Hacking (1994) has described as 'looping effects', the reaction of people to the classes to which they and their activities are consigned. This reaction may range all the way from passive acceptance to militant refusal. In other words, the meaning of human kinds develops and changes in the course of interactions among those affected. (This interaction has sometimes been described as a process of 'negotiation', though that implies a more deliberate and more articulate process than is often the case.) Human kinds of the sort discussed in this book are not natural kinds, but neither are they mere legends. They do refer to features that

are real. But it is a reality in which they are themselves heavily implicated, a reality of which they are a part.

The reality to which human kinds refer is a cultural reality, and that in several senses: first, because the phenomena depicted are ones which exist only in some cultural context; secondly, because these phenomena commonly depend on a certain social technology for their visibility and their production; thirdly – and this is the aspect that has been the focus here – because the categories used in their representation are culturally grounded. What implications does this grounding have for Psychology's scientific project?

The categories of scientific Psychology are partly derived from certain taken for granted, but historically formed, distinctions and partly reflect the requirements of a scientific community in the making. Much of the time there is little or no conflict between these factors. This is not surprising, because the society that generated the first modern psychological categories was the same society that gave rise to the normative order of empirical science. However, this society was never a monolith. Although it was marked by certain pervasive features, its numerous divisions also created much dissonance. One source of dissonance was the division between lay knowledge and scientific knowledge. In the case of psychology the division was particularly troublesome because human action is action under some description, so that, if Psychology was to study this topic, the choice between accepting the lay description and imposing its own description was ever present. Popular relevance meant respecting lay categories, but the project of building a scientific community required a different kind of language. Where lay usage depended on innumerable local contexts and subtle distinctions, scientific usage demanded abstract categories and precise, not subtle, distinctions.

The more uncompromising psychologists became in their exclusive commitment to the requirements of scientific language the more impoverished their descriptions became, at least from the point of view of ordinary usage. But this was hardly seen as a sacrifice by many practitioners who valued the pursuit of universality and accuracy above all else. The successful development of a methodologically based meta-language, as described in Chapter 9, was the fruit of this pursuit. However, it was a dry, shrivelled fruit that provided limited sustenance for those who wanted to see a unification of the discipline on the basis of scientific theory. What was commonly overlooked was that the culturally rather narrow foundations of the discipline already provided it with a kind of unity. After the first third of the twentieth century Psychology became essentially an American discipline. This was not only because, for a while, the scale of its practice in the rest of the world paled into insignificance compared to its exuberant growth in the United States. More significantly, it was imported, and sometimes reimported, by the rest of the world as part and parcel of its importation of

American values, American educational and business practices, American media, American advertising, American conceptions of mental health, and so on. For this reason, if for no other, an exploration of the historical foundations of American psychology has international significance.

This study is incomplete in a number of respects. For one thing, the categories selected for attention form but a part of even the most general categories of American-style Psychology, let alone its more specific categories. Hopefully, others will be examined in due course, especially categories that have achieved prominence more recently, like cognition. Our focus on a limited time period eliminated many potential candidates. Equally important is the recognition that there have been many alternative ways of categorizing psychological phenomena that do not form part of the main course taken by American Psychology. This does not mean that they belong in the dustbin of psychology's history. Quite the contrary.

There are only two things we can be sure of in speculating about future developments. One is that this is not the end of history; in other words, that the categories of psychology will continue to change. In this process old categories will acquire new meaning and some will be discarded altogether. New categories will take their place, and some of these may represent traditions that were in eclipse for much of the twentieth century. The second belief which may be asserted with some confidence is that changes in psychological categories will continue to be heavily dependent on changes in the societies within which these categories have a role. Their meaning will continue to be negotiated and contested among the groups to whom they matter. As the identity of these groups changes, both nationally and globally, the kinds that seem so natural today will become tomorrow's legends.

Notes

1. This emphasis on the normative significance of psychological categories owes much to the work of Foucault, especially Foucault (1977). This aspect of Foucault's work has been further developed by a number of authors (see especially Rose, 1996). Commenting on the implications of Foucault's analysis, Joseph Rouse (1987: 217) writes: 'Classifications provide intelligible ways for people to understand themselves (and the things around them) and to act. The imposition of new categories that come to figure in our various configurations of possible action constrains people in significant ways and even produces different kinds of people. *Classification is an important form of power*' (italics added).

2. This problematic began to have an influence on psychological research some years ago, see e.g. Medin (1989); Nelson (1991).

3. The philosopher Hilary Putnam has frequently emphasized this point: 'We can and should insist that some facts are there to be discovered and not legislated by us. But this is something to be said when one has adopted a way of speaking, a language, a 'conceptual scheme'. To talk of 'facts' without specifying the language to be used is to talk of nothing' (Putnam, 1991: 114).

4. The notion of 'relevant kinds' was introduced by the philosopher Nelson Goodman in the course of his demonstration that any process of induction depends on taking certain classes as relevant and others as irrelevant. Relevance is a matter of emphasizing certain distinctions and de-emphasizing others, and this can account for differences between one constructed world and another: 'Some relevant kinds of the one world, rather than being absent from the other, are present as irrelevant kinds; some differences among worlds are not so much in entities comprised as in emphasis or accent, and these differences are no less consequential. Just as to stress all syllables is to stress none, so to take all classes as relevant kinds is to take none as such' (Goodman, 1978: 11).

5. One of the very few attempts by a psychologist to address the problem of natural kinds pins its hopes on so-called 'micropsychology', operating with units that simply involve 'a change of behavior, e.g. a change in the direction of gaze' (Fiske, 1991). The advantages of operating at this level would however be purely technical (e.g. clearer category boundaries); the basic dependence of data on classificatory schemes remains unaffected. The choice of such categories as 'behaviour' and 'gaze', for example, is driven by certain historical traditions, not by anything in the 'nature' of the case, and the observations reported within this framework are just that: observations made possible by adopting this framework rather than another.

6. These considerations ultimately derive from Wittgenstein's (1953) strictures on private language. The psychological implications of Wittgenstein's insights have been extensively developed by a number of authors, Bloor (1983), Coulter (1989), and Harré and Gillett (1994) among others. For anthropological perspectives on the discursive formation of psychological objects, see Lutz and Abu-Lughod (1990).

7. This tendency can lend credibility to a sharp juxtaposition of social constructionism and realism, as in Greenwood (1994).

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